



BANDEEP SINGH

ABOVE PAR



GOLF EXPERIENCE LEH GOLF COURSE

At 11,302 feet above sea level, facing the towering gompas and stupas over the cliffs, the Leh golf course provides a transcendental experience. Glancing at a bone-dry fairway of yellow sand without a single tuft of grass and brown, you realise this place is beyond colours—no greens here but only sand mixed with bitumen and burnt oil. You transcend your handicap, when a blast of wind carries the ball 30 metres closer to making the putt with the same worn-out club. And finally, you transcend the game, as you lose the ball against the grandiose view of the jagged peaks that surround the course. You stand still in stupefied awe, overwhelmed by the sheer scale of this grand coliseum of nature. Originally named the Trishul Golf Course, the 18-hole 7,231-yard par-72 course was developed way back in 1967. Now under a different name—the Army Environmental Park—the course offers a golfing experience spiced with the best that the army

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has to offer—ungrudging caddies, Rs 100-a-day course fees and a luxurious wood-panelled clubhouse and bar for its 50 members. It is a circuitous process to play at the course as you need permission from the army headquarters and the district collector. But at the end of the day, golf at the world's highest course is less about the birdies and bogies. You take home a score card of finer experience—of hearing the loudest-ever clink when you hit the ball amid the overbearing tranquility; of hitting each shot from a small mat of astroturf that you carry in your bag; of hitting out of tees like the Guinness top—at 3,445 metres, the highest tee-off point in the world; and in winter months, staring at an expanse of white as you poise to swing at your fluorescent golf ball. What you take is something more, of playing a game of luxury that gently subjugates all the harsh, untamed elements at that altitude—it is a high much beyond golf.

by **Bandeep Singh**